

Glossary

Active birth An approach to childbirth that involves upright positions and movements during labor.

Alphafetoprotein (AFP) A substance produced by the embryonic yolk sac, and later the fetal liver, that can be found in mother's bloodstream in pregnancy.

Amniocentesis Removal of a small amount of amniotic fluid through the abdomen, usually carried out as a test for fetal abnormalities.

Amnion The thin membrane surrounding the fetus and the amniotic fluid, also known as the amniotic sac.

Amniotic fluid The fluid that surrounds and protects the fetus.

Amniotomy The surgical rupture of the amniotic sac, done to speed up labor.

Anterior position See [Occiput anterior](#).

Apgar score A test of the baby's well-being given shortly after the birth to assess heart rate and tone, respiration, blood circulation, and nerve responses.

Areola The pigmented circle of skin surrounding the nipple.

AROM Artificial rupture of the membranes. See [Amniotomy](#).

Bilirubin A normal byproduct in the breakdown of red blood cells, some newborns have levels too high for their liver to metabolize, which results in neonatal jaundice.

Blastocyst An early stage of the developing embryo when it has divided into a group of cells.

Bloody show A vaginal discharge of blood-stained mucus caused by cervical dilatation. A sign that labor is starting.

Braxton Hicks contractions Practice contractions of the uterus that occur throughout pregnancy, but which may not be noticed until toward the end.

Breech presentation When the position of the baby in the uterus is bottom down rather than head down.

Catheter A thin plastic tube inserted into the body through a natural channel to withdraw or introduce fluid.

Cephalic presentation (Vertex presentation) The position of a baby who is head down in the uterus. The most common presentation.

Cephalopelvic disproportion A state in which the head of the fetus is larger than the cavity of the mother's pelvis.

Cervical dilation See [Dilation](#).

Chorion The outer membranous tissue that envelops the fetus and placenta.

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Chorionic gonadotropin See [Human chorionic gonadotropin \(hCG\)](#).

Chorionic villus sampling A screening for genetic abnormality by analysis of tissue from the small protrusions on the outer membrane enveloping the embryo that later form the placenta.